society, including the Sri Lankan Tamil community, for a life of equality, justice, peace and dignity in a united Sri Lanka.'[1]

Modi visited Nepal twice in the space of six months – August 2014 and November 2014. On the first bilateral visit by an Indian prime minister to this critical Himalayan neighbour since 1998, in August 2014, Modi spoke of the old civilizational relationship between India and Nepal, referring to them 'as old as the Himalayas and the Ganga'. Like Sri Lanka, here too Modi tried to assuage resentment of India as big brother by saying, 'We have not come here to interfere in your internal matters but we want to help you to develop.'[2] During his November 2014 trip, $1 billion line of credit was offered for building Nepalese infrastructure and hydropower. Regular bus services between the two countries are now envisaged in addition to creating ease of travel for private vehicles across the border, promoting trade, tourism and regional connectivity.[3]

While relations with Sri Lanka have improved, those with Nepal seem to have their ups and downs. In late 2015, political unrest over the new Nepalese Constitution resulting from disagreements between Madhesis (ethnic Indians who have lived in Nepal for centuries) and the Nepalese government adversely impacted India–Nepal ties. The subsequent unrest and violence also resulted in Madhesis blocking all entry points from India into Nepal. Given Nepal's dependence on transit trade through India, the blockade lasting several weeks hurt landlocked Nepal and was perceived as having been supported by New Delhi.[4] Nepal offered to sign a fuel deal with China during Prime Minister Oli's maiden trip to Beijing in an obvious effort to get India's attention. Instead of signing a fuel agreement with China, the Nepal government preferred seeking a meeting of the Eminent Persons Group (EPG) created in 2014 to review the gamut of India–Nepal relations including the 1950 treaty of peace and friendship.[5]

Regional connectivity – trade, tourism and travel – between the South Asian countries has been key to Modi's push for South Asia. It would